THE PINK LEMON



Why Losing Isn't Always What It Looks Like

CHRIS MARVEL DAVIS

CHAPTER ONE

Not One

I loved baseball before I had much language for winning or losing. I grew up in Cleveland in the 1990s, which was a pretty good place and time to fall in love with baseball. The Indians had a loaded roster, with players like Kenny Lofton, Albert Belle, and Omar Vizquel. A city that had spent years waiting for a championship could convince itself pretty quickly that this might finally be the team.

They reached the World Series twice during that decade and lost both times. As a kid, I couldn't explain why being so close made the losses hurt more. I knew only that I wanted my team to win, and that I loved playing the game myself.

I watched games, practiced, played pickup ball with friends, and spent time in batting cages. On trips to the library with my dad, I would grab baseball books along with whatever else caught my attention. *Nolan Ryan's Pitcher's Bible* is one I remember, but it was not the only one. I was interested in the players, but I also wanted to understand how to get better. I wondered why one person could throw harder and why somebody else was a better hitter. What did practice actually change? I don't think I would have said it that way as a kid. I just wanted to know how people got good.

My dad gave me a fairly simple answer to what you did when you weren't good enough yet. You kept going. That was how he approached a lot of life. If something didn't work, you didn't wait

around forever feeling sorry for yourself. You figured out what you needed to do and you tried again. Nobody was going to care enough about your situation to climb inside of it and fix your life for you. I still believe that.

There are losses where the answer really is that simple. You were not prepared, someone worked harder, or another person developed a skill you did not have. Maybe you got distracted, let fear take over, or assumed wanting something would be enough. It happens. If I was not good enough or failed to prepare, I would rather know than have somebody protect my feelings with a story that is not true. Talking about failure should not excuse us from looking honestly at our part.

Baseball taught me some of that. It also taught me that it wasn't the whole story. By the time I tried out for my high school team in eleventh grade, I felt ready. At least I felt like the version of ready I understood. I had played, practiced, and learned the game as I knew it then.

Then you get around other kids who have been preparing for the same opportunity and you start seeing details you didn't know were details. Some had better equipment. Some had played more organized baseball. Some had access to travel teams, coaching, and repetitions that neighborhood pickup games couldn't completely replace. None of that meant they didn't work; they did. It also didn't mean I had done nothing; I hadn't.

We had reached the same tryout by different roads. That may have been the first time I understood how many people can care deeply about the same opportunity. The roster had only so many places; wanting one was not going to make my preparation equivalent to everyone else's.

Many people want the customer, too. Wanting something badly can feel special when you are alone with that desire. Then you walk into a room full of people who want it just as badly and realize that desire is only the starting point. Preparation, access, and the small details begin to matter.

I made the team, and that matters because for years I judged the story by how it ended. When the ending disappointed me, I treated the entire experience as a disappointment. Then I got injured. I never really got to see what my full potential in baseball might have been. That's the story. I don't need to turn it into anything bigger than it was. At the time, though, I was disappointed. Baseball had occupied enough space in my imagination that losing the chance to continue with it required me to find other things to imagine.

I grieved it. Then eventually I moved on. What I didn't understand yet was why this particular loss felt different from some of the ones I had experienced before. If another kid struck me out, there was information in that. He might have had a better pitch, my timing might have been off, or I might have needed more practice against that kind of delivery. An injury didn't give me the same information. I had spent a lot of my childhood learning that losing was evidence. You lose, so you go improve, practice more, and figure out what the winner did that you didn't.

The injury ended the season without answering those questions. That was difficult to fit into the rules I had learned. I had done enough to make the team, and I still did not get to play the season I had imagined. For a while, I treated the second fact as if it canceled the first.

As I have gotten older, I have noticed how quickly we reach for an explanation. We say the winner worked harder, the loser did not want it enough, the successful company must have made better decisions,

and the failed company must have made bad ones. The marriage that lasted was healthy, and the one that ended was a mistake. Sometimes that's exactly right. Often the story is more complicated, and we're reading the ending backward, inventing a story that makes the outcome feel inevitable.

We do this with winners, too. After somebody succeeds, we look backward and begin treating ordinary details as clues that success was inevitable. A morning routine, a particular mindset, or a book on the shelf becomes the explanation, even when we do not know how much it mattered. The coach they hired and the discipline they showed may have mattered too. But we rarely look as closely at people who did many of the same things and still lost.

I did not understand any of that in eleventh grade. I just knew baseball was becoming something I used to do. Other interests moved forward. Life moved. Years later, when I started teaching, coaching, building businesses, raising sons, and losing things that cost considerably more than a baseball season, I found myself returning to that basic question. What does a loss actually prove? Sometimes quite a bit, and sometimes almost nothing.

That distinction matters because of what we tend to do next. When people care about you, they usually want to make pain useful quickly. People say things like, "Everything happens for a reason," "God has something better," "This is making you stronger," or "Keep your head up." I understand the impulse because I have said those things myself.

I am a Christian. I believe God can use things I would never have chosen. I also don't think my faith requires me to pretend I understand why every painful thing happened. Those are different claims. There are things in my life that became useful later. There are losses that redirected me. There are things that broke down and eventually

became material for something else. I can see that now because enough time has passed. But I don't think that means every bad thing is fertilizer and we're just supposed to keep digging until we find the flower. Sometimes we don't know. Sometimes the only honest sentence available is, *I hate that this happened.* I have become more comfortable with that.

What concerns me more is what we do when we skip understanding the loss and move directly to fixing ourselves. If somebody beats you because they were better, improvement makes sense. If the loss came down to something nearly random, that requires a different conversation. If something was taken from you, searching endlessly for your personal failure may turn into punishment. If you've been winning the wrong game, working harder may actually move you further from the life you want. If you walked away because staying had become too expensive, calling yourself a quitter may completely misunderstand the decision. Those are different losses. I didn't know that when I was seventeen. I knew one thing: get back up. I'm grateful my father taught me that, and the habit has carried me through difficult seasons. Learning when to keep moving and where to direct that effort took me much longer.

KEEP READING

That was one kind of loss. There are five.

The rest of *The Pink Lemon* sorts them out:

1. Somebody beat you
2. The margin was almost random
3. Something was taken
4. You were playing the wrong game
5. You walked out

Each one asks for a different response.

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